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ACLU looks to stop more cities from installing automatic license plate readers

By [Brian Tabick](#)

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CORALVILLE, Iowa (KCRG) - The ACLU of Iowa is raising constitutional concerns about new surveillance technology being considered in Coralville.



The city of Coralville is looking to join other communities in Eastern Iowa to install automatic license plates for readers like Flock cameras.

Flock cameras scan car license plates, and police can use that data to find suspects or build an investigation, but the ACLU said this type of surveillance is essentially breaking people's Fourth Amendment right to a reasonable search and seizure. It's also worried about what happens to that data after it's collected.

Linda Petersen joined almost two dozen people in a conference room at the Coralville Library to ask the ACLU about its concerns over Automated License Plate Readers like the Flock cameras the city is currently looking into.

"We don't know if they are tracking people's license plates, we don't know whose getting that data, who has access to that data," said Petersen. "It just seems to be much more of a surveillance state."

If approved by the city council, Coralville would join a growing list of communities in Eastern Iowa to install Flock cameras. Cedar Rapids, North Liberty, and Dubuque already have this technology in place.

"The new increase in the number of cameras, but how they are being used, that has us really concerned," said Rebecca Eastwood, the ACLU Deputy Policy Director.

She said they are now in the early stages of trying to stop more cities from installing these cameras until they can learn more about what these private companies are doing with the video and who else has access to it.

"The functionality of them allows for misuse," she said. "It allows for abuse of people, the government is trying to track someone down," said Eastwood.

A Flock spokesperson tells TV9 that it isn't happening.

In a statement, Flock's technology is built to serve communities while upholding each community's own laws and values. We do not write laws or enforce them; instead, we build

safeguards like policy attestations, audit reporting, and proactive search filters to ensure compliance, transparency, and trust.

Local agencies always retain full ownership and control of their data. They decide if, when, and with whom to share their data with and can revoke access at any time. An agency can only share data from their own cameras. Flock simply provides the platform for collaboration, enabling partnerships that have helped solve serious crimes while ensuring local oversight remains intact.

Flock remains committed to public trust and goes beyond legal requirements by engineering accountability into our technology. When compliance issues arise, we act swiftly, and if sharing violates state or local policy, we can remove access immediately. Our mission is to ensure communities can use life-saving technology responsibly, in alignment with their democratic values.”

In Cedar Rapids, the footage is stored for 30 days after that, Flock said the video is deleted and unrecoverable. However, Petersen believes that where she goes is of no business to the police or anyone else.

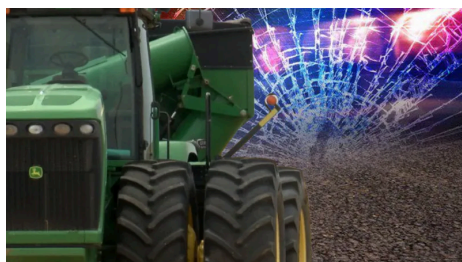
“Stores that I go to, places that I shop, places that I visit within my community; that’s essentially spying on me,” said Petersen.

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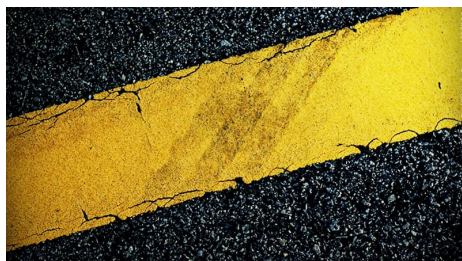
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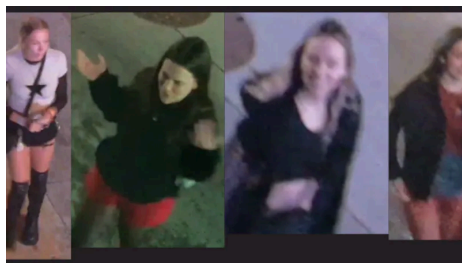
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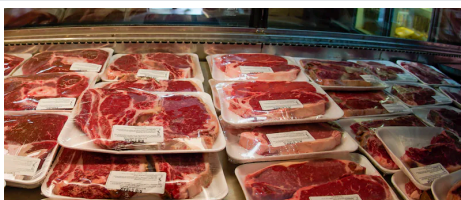
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